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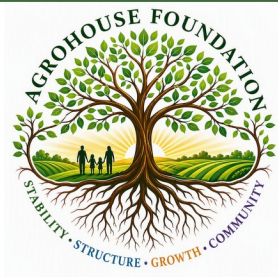
Community Outreach • Sustainable Agriculture • Workforce Development

Garden Planning Workbook

A Step-by-Step Guide to Planning a Productive, Sustainable Garden

STABILITY • STRUCTURE • GROWTH • COMMUNITY

Prepared by: AgroHouse Foundation™ • Best suited for: Florida Gardens (USDA Zones 9a–9b) • Use with: Program 2 – Farm Infrastructure & Operations • Format: Printable Planning Workbook



Thank You for Your Donation

On behalf of AgroHouse Foundation™ and the families and communities we serve, thank you for your generous donation. Your support directly helps fund community outreach, sustainable agriculture, and workforce development programs.

As a small token of our appreciation, please enjoy this copy of the Garden Planning Workbook — our gift to you.

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Welcome to Your Garden Planning Workbook

Whether you are planning a backyard raised bed, a container garden on a patio, or helping lay the groundwork for a future community farm, this workbook will walk you through every stage of the planning process. It is designed to be used with a pencil in hand — print the worksheet pages, fill them in, and revisit them season after season as your garden grows.

AgroHouse Foundation™ created this workbook to support families, volunteers, and community partners who want to build long-term food security through sustainable, low-cost growing practices. Gardening is one of the most accessible ways to build stability: it reduces grocery costs, improves nutrition, creates opportunities for shared learning, and strengthens the bond between a household and its community.

How to Use This Workbook

- Read Sections 1–3 before you dig your first bed — good planning prevents wasted time and money.
- Worksheets are meant to be reused. Photocopy or print extra copies each season.
- Keep this workbook in a binder or garden folder so you can compare year over year.
- There is no need to complete every worksheet before starting — begin with what is useful to you now.

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Section 1: Garden Planning Basics

Every successful garden begins with an honest look at the space you have to work with. Before choosing seeds or building beds, take time to assess sunlight, soil, water access, and how much time you can realistically commit each week.

Site Assessment Checklist

- Sunlight — observe the space at 9am, 12pm, and 3pm; most vegetables need 6–8 hours of direct sun
- Soil — note current soil type (sandy, clay, loamy) and drainage after a heavy rain
- Water access — is there a hose bib or rain barrel within reach of the growing area?
- Slope & drainage — does water pool anywhere after rain, or drain away too quickly?
- Existing structures — fences, trees, or buildings that cast shade or block airflow
- Wildlife pressure — deer, rabbits, or other animals that may require fencing
- Accessibility — can you comfortably reach all planting areas for weeding and harvest?

Setting Realistic Goals

New gardeners often start too big. A smaller, well-tended garden will almost always out-produce a large, neglected one. Consider starting with one or two 4x8 raised beds or a set of containers, then expand in future seasons as you learn your site's conditions and your own available time.

Worksheet 1.1 — My Garden Goals

Primary purpose (choose one or more): ☐ Household food ☐ Sharing with neighbors ☐ Community donation ☐ Learning/education ☐ Income supplement

Hours available per week for garden care: _____

Household members who will help: _____

Target first-season crops (3–5 items): _____

Budget available for this season: _____

Section 2: Florida Growing Zones & Planting Calendar

Most of central Florida, including Pasco County, falls within USDA Hardiness Zones 9a and 9b. This means mild winters, a long growing season, and the ability to grow crops nearly year-round — but it also means summer heat and humidity can be tough on cool-season vegetables. Florida gardeners generally plant in three overlapping seasons rather than the traditional spring/summer/fall pattern used in northern states.

Central Florida Planting Calendar (Zone 9a/9b Guide)

Season	Approx. Months	Well-Suited Crops
Cool Season	Oct – Feb	Broccoli, cabbage, carrots, collards, lettuce, kale, onions, snap peas, radishes, strawberries
Warm Season	Feb/Mar – May	Tomatoes, peppers, squash, cucumbers, beans, corn, eggplant, watermelon, basil
Hot/Humid Season	Jun – Sep	Okra, sweet potatoes, southern peas, roselle, malabar spinach, heat-tolerant herbs



Season	Approx. Months	Well-Suited Crops
Second Warm Window	Late Aug – Oct	A second planting of tomatoes, peppers, and beans as heat begins to ease

This calendar is a general guide. Always check current-year frost dates and local extension office recommendations, since timing shifts slightly from year to year and with microclimates.

Worksheet 2.1 — My Planting Timeline

Cool season crops to plant: _____

Target cool season planting date: _____

Warm season crops to plant: _____

Target warm season planting date: _____

Hot/humid season crops to plant: _____

Section 3: Garden Bed Layout Worksheet

A clear layout keeps taller plants from shading shorter ones, groups plants with similar water needs, and makes it easier to rotate crops each season. Use the grid below to sketch your garden, or copy it onto graph paper for a larger design.

Bed Planning Notes

Bed / Area Name	Dimensions	Sun Exposure	Planned Crop(s)
Example: Bed 1	4 ft x 8 ft	Full sun	Tomatoes, basil, marigold border

Spacing Guidelines (Quick Reference)

Crop	Spacing Between Plants	Spacing Between Rows
Tomatoes	24–36 in	36–48 in
Peppers	18–24 in	24–30 in
Squash / Cucumbers	24–36 in	36–48 in
Bush Beans	4–6 in	18–24 in
Leafy Greens	6–12 in	12–18 in
Root Vegetables	2–4 in	12–18 in
Herbs (basil, etc.)	8–12 in	12–18 in



Section 4: Crop Selection & Companion Planting Guide

Companion planting pairs crops that support one another — through pest deterrence, shared nutrient needs, or efficient use of space. The table below offers a starting point for a diversified, resilient garden bed.

Crop	Good Companions	Avoid Planting Near
Tomatoes	Basil, marigold, carrots, onions	Corn, fennel, cabbage family
Peppers	Basil, onions, carrots	Fennel
Squash	Corn, beans, marigold, nasturtium	Potatoes
Beans	Corn, squash, carrots, cucumbers	Onions, garlic
Cucumbers	Beans, corn, radishes, sunflowers	Aromatic herbs, potatoes
Cabbage Family	Dill, onions, herbs	Tomatoes, strawberries
Carrots	Onions, tomatoes, beans, peas	Dill (mature)

Choosing Crops for Your Household

- Grow what your household will actually eat — a productive harvest is only valuable if it gets used
- Mix quick-maturing crops (radishes, lettuce) with longer-season crops (tomatoes, peppers) for a steady harvest
- Include a few pollinator-friendly flowers (marigold, zinnia, sunflower) to support fruit set
- Consider crops that store or preserve well if your household wants to build a food reserve

Section 5: Soil & Bed Preparation

Florida's native soil is often sandy and low in organic matter, which means it drains quickly but does not hold nutrients well. Building healthy soil is the single most important investment a gardener can make — it pays off in every season that follows.

Basic Soil Preparation Steps

- Clear the area of grass, weeds, and debris.
- Loosen existing soil to a depth of 8–12 inches if planting directly in ground.
- Amend with compost or aged manure at a ratio of roughly 30–40% compost to native soil.
- For raised beds, use a blended mix of topsoil, compost, and a coarse material (such as perlite or coarse sand) for drainage.
- Test soil pH if possible; most vegetables prefer a pH between 6.0 and 6.8.
- Apply a 2–3 inch layer of mulch (straw, leaves, or wood chips) to retain moisture and suppress weeds.

Low-Cost Soil Building Tip

Composting kitchen scraps, coffee grounds, and yard waste is one of the most affordable ways to build soil fertility over time. A simple three-bin or tumbler system can turn household waste into usable compost within a few months.



Section 6: Watering & Irrigation Planning

Consistent watering matters more than volume. Most vegetable gardens need roughly 1–1.5 inches of water per week, delivered slowly so it soaks in rather than runs off. Florida’s sandy soil drains fast, so frequent, shorter waterings often work better than infrequent deep soakings.

Irrigation Options

Method	Best For	Notes
Hand watering	Small beds, containers	Low cost; time-intensive
Soaker hose	Raised beds, rows	Even, low-waste watering directly to roots
Drip irrigation	Larger gardens	Efficient; higher upfront cost, low ongoing cost
Rain barrel collection	Any size	Reduces water cost; dependent on rainfall

Watering Best Practices

- Water early in the morning to reduce evaporation and fungal disease risk
- Water at the base of the plant rather than overhead when possible
- Check soil moisture 2 inches down before watering — if damp, wait
- Adjust watering frequency during Florida’s rainy season (June–September)

Section 7: Seasonal Task Calendar Worksheet

Use this worksheet to plan monthly garden tasks. Copy it at the start of each season and fill it in as you go — it becomes a useful record for planning next year’s garden.

Month	Planting Tasks	Maintenance Tasks	Harvest Notes
Month 1			
Month 2			
Month 3			
Month 4			

Recurring Task Reminders

- Check soil moisture 2–3 times per week
- Inspect for pests and disease weekly
- Refresh mulch as it breaks down
- Fertilize or top-dress with compost every 4–6 weeks during active growth
- Rotate crop families each season to reduce soil-borne disease buildup



Section 8: Pest & Disease Management Basics

Florida's warm, humid climate supports a wide range of garden pests and fungal diseases. A proactive, low-chemical approach protects your harvest while keeping the garden safe for households, pollinators, and community members.

Common Signs & First Steps

Sign	Likely Cause	First Response
Chewed leaves	Caterpillars, beetles	Hand-pick pests; introduce row covers
Sticky residue / curled leaves	Aphids	Spray with strong water stream; introduce ladybugs
White powdery coating	Powdery mildew	Improve airflow; avoid overhead watering
Yellowing, wilting despite water	Root rot / overwatering	Check drainage; reduce watering frequency
Holes in fruit	Fruit worms, stink bugs	Remove affected fruit; monitor regularly

Integrated Pest Management (IPM) Principles

- Start with prevention: healthy soil and proper spacing reduce most problems before they start.
- Identify the pest correctly before treating — not all insects are harmful.
- Use the least-toxic option first (hand removal, water spray, row covers).
- Reserve stronger treatments for confirmed, significant infestations.

Section 9: Harvest & Yield Tracking Worksheet

Tracking your harvest helps you plan quantities for next season and, for community-connected gardens, provides simple documentation of impact that can support grant reporting and partnership updates.

Crop	Date Harvested	Quantity	Notes

Section 10: Community Garden Considerations

Gardens grown with community outreach in mind carry extra considerations — scale, shared labor, food safety, and coordination with partner organizations. This section applies to households growing to share or donate, and to future community or partner-based growing spaces.



Planning for Shared or Donated Harvests

- Coordinate with the receiving partner in advance about quantities, delivery timing, and accepted crops
- Harvest at proper ripeness and handle produce gently to preserve freshness for donation
- Keep basic records of what is donated, to whom, and approximate quantity
- Wash hands and use clean containers when handling produce intended for others
- Communicate any use of pesticides or treatments to the receiving partner

Connecting to AgroHouse Foundation™'s Mission

Every garden — from a single raised bed to a future community farm — supports AgroHouse Foundation™'s mission of food security, sustainability, and community stewardship. Sharing what you grow, teaching a neighbor a new skill, or simply reducing your household's grocery costs all contribute to a stronger, more self-sufficient community.

Resources & Support

This workbook is intended as a general educational resource and does not replace guidance from your local UF/IFAS County Extension Office, which offers free, region-specific advice, soil testing information, and gardening classes.

- Local UF/IFAS Extension Office — soil testing, plant clinics, and seasonal planting guidance
- AgroHouse Foundation™ community partners — for households interested in shared growing space or donating surplus produce
- Seed libraries and local garden clubs — often free or low-cost sources of seeds and knowledge

Thank you for growing with us. Every bed planted is a step toward a more stable, self-sufficient community.

This workbook is provided for general educational purposes. AgroHouse Foundation™ is not responsible for individual gardening outcomes; always follow product labels and local regulations when using fertilizers or pest treatments.